CEI Methods Committee Charter

Oct 31, 2026 · Proposed for adoption by the CEI board

1. Purpose and authority

The Methods Committee exists so that no one at CEI, and no funder, decides alone which moral traditions are included in CEI's benchmarks or how they are scored. The committee decides, as final under this policy: (a) the published criteria for including a tradition, framework or source (Annex); (b) approval of each module's task specifications, reference-answer protocol and validation plan before they are registered; (c) the judge–human agreement thresholds and item-retention rules; and (d) whether a module may be scored and released. A module the committee blocks stays blocked.

This authority is a self-binding board policy, not a delegation. Under California law a committee that includes non-directors cannot exercise the board's authority, so the board binds itself as follows:

- The board keeps the legal responsibility California law places on it.
- CEI staff and leadership carry out the committee's decisions on (a) to (d) as final.
- The board sets a decision aside only if two-thirds of the directors in office find, after written notice to the committee and 30 days for the committee to reconsider, that carrying it out would break the law, breach a binding agreement, exceed the approved budget, or be withheld by the fiscal sponsor.
- The board publishes its finding and does not substitute its own method decision.
- This section and §8 are amended only as §8 provides.
- The Executive Director's annual evaluation includes compliance with this policy.

2. What the committee does not decide

- **Who speaks for a tradition.** The tradition's own partner panel, under the Tradition Partner Charter, authors and ratifies its reference points, and only that panel recognizes its module as faithful. The committee checks that the panel and protocol meet that charter; it does not substitute its reading of a tradition for the panel's.
- **Whether results are favorable.** The committee reviews method, not outcomes. It has no power to delay, soften or veto the publication of any result, and it does not see a lab's results before the lab does.

- **Budget and staffing,** which remain with the board, except that the board commits to fund any committee-approved module within the annual budget or to state publicly why not.

3. Composition and independence

- Five to seven voting members, including at least two secular moral philosophers, at least one machine-learning or evaluation researcher, one measurement or psychometrics specialist, and at least two scholars of religious traditions, at least one from a tradition other than Christianity.
- A majority of members from outside Christianity, the founders' tradition.
- When the committee reviews, blocks or hears an appeal on a module, a scholar of that tradition who is not on its partner panel sits with the committee for that decision, with a vote (§5).
- No voting member may be a CEI director, CEI staff, a current employee of a lab whose models CEI evaluates, or a representative of a funder. A representative of a funder is an employee, officer, director or agent of a funder that gave to CEI in the past three years.
- The president attends without a vote; the v1 lead attends as needed.
- Membership is published, with affiliations and declared conflicts.

4. Appointment, terms and removal

- Members are appointed by the board on nomination by the president, any two directors or the committee. Any current tradition partner may propose a nominee to any of them. Once its first five members are seated, the committee is consulted on every nomination.
- While the president serves as interim leader, the president does not vote on appointments.
- Three-year terms, renewable once. The first cohort draws one-, two- and three-year terms by lot, so that no more than half the seats turn over in a year. The first five members are to be named by a date the board sets.
- The committee elects its own chair for a one-year term.
- A member may be removed only for cause (an undisclosed conflict, sustained non-participation, or a breach of confidentiality over unreleased test items) by two-thirds of the directors in office, after the member is heard and the committee consulted, with

the reason published.

5. How it works

- Meets at least quarterly and before every scoring freeze; a majority of voting members is a quorum.
- Ordinary decisions by majority of those present. Blocking a module, declining a specification or changing the inclusion criteria needs a majority of all voting members.
- For a decision that reviews, blocks or hears an appeal on a module, a scholar of the tradition under review who is not on its partner panel, chosen by the committee, sits with a vote and is named with the decision.
- Every dissent is recorded and published with the decision.
- Minutes are published within 30 days, redacted only for unreleased test items and personal data.
- Members declare conflicts annually and item by item, and recuse from any decision about a module their institution authored, a lab that employs or funds them, or a funder they represent.
- The committee may decline a panel that is an instrument of a state or a political movement, and says so publicly.
- Deliberations may be confidential; decisions, criteria and reasons are public.

6. Standing duties

1. Adopt and publish the inclusion criteria for traditions, frameworks and sources (Annex), answer every proposal in writing, publish the queue, and review the criteria yearly.
2. Approve each module's task specifications, reference-answer protocol and validation plan before registration (Open Science Framework) and before items are written at scale.
3. Apply the three agreement rules, kept apart:
    - Scholar panels decide by vote, not by a statistic. A reference point is settled when two of three panel scholars ratify the same reference point, and contested otherwise. Krippendorff's α is reported per module as a description of the panel; it never labels an item.

    - AI judges. A dimension is reported from an AI judge only where judge–human Krippendorff's α is at least 0.80 on a held-out sample never used to write judge prompts. Between 0.67 and 0.80 the dimension is reported as tentative with a 20% human audit. Below 0.67 it is human-rated or dropped.
    - Ceiling. Judge–human agreement must be within 0.10 of human–human agreement on the same sample. The thresholds are set per dimension, validated at the claim level, and refreshed at each item rotation and for each new model family. The refusal classifier reports its own agreement.
4. Confirm the item-retention rule (contested items kept and labeled, never averaged away or dropped) and the minimum reportable cell.
5. Review the validation results, including capability correlation across 20 or more open models and between-module correlations, and decide whether each module may be scored. No test-split run begins and no profile report is published before that decision.
6. Resolve method disputes between CEI staff and a tradition partner, and hear partner appeals.
7. Publish a short annual report on what it approved, blocked and changed, and why.

7. Board and committee: the conflict rule

- If the board declines to fund a committee-approved module, it publishes the reason.
- If the committee blocks a module, the board may not release it.
- If the board believes a committee decision breaks the law, breaches a binding agreement, exceeds the budget or would be withheld by the fiscal sponsor, it follows §1: written notice, 30 days for the committee to reconsider, a two-thirds vote of the directors in office, a published finding, and no substitute method decision.
- Neither body reviews results before publication. One narrow exception: counsel may review a report's text for legal exposure (defamation, breach of a pre-release agreement) before release. Numbers never change; every edit made on that review is logged in the report.

8. Support, reporting and amendment

- CEI provides staff support (through the interim leader until the first paid hire) and a budget line for members' honoraria: $2K budgeted in 2027; members may serve pro bono.

- The committee reports to the board quarterly in writing and meets the full board once a year.
- This charter is amended only by two-thirds of the directors in office after consulting the committee. Every amendment is published with its reason 30 days before it takes effect.

9. When this charter takes force

- This charter takes force at the first scoring freeze for a public release.
- Until then, a three-person interim methods panel, named by the board and meeting the independence rules in §3, advises CEI on method. Its advice is recorded and published with any result it concerns.
- Work labeled pilot or exploratory on the development split may be published before the committee is seated, carrying that label.
- No test-split run begins and no profile report is published before the committee is seated and has decided under §6.5.

Annex: inclusion criteria

A tradition, school or source is included in CEI's benchmarks when all four hold:

1. A partner panel meeting Tradition Partner Charter §5 is willing to author it.
2. Its scope and source are named: a text, a school, a body, or a tradition whose panel spans its recognized schools.
3. A budget exists for it, or the partner brings one.
4. The committee publishes its reason for including it.

- Any scholar or body may propose a module. The committee answers in writing within 90 days and publishes the queue with its reasons.
- Readiness is not a criterion. That a benchmark, a declaration or a rubric already exists for a tradition counts neither for nor against it.
- The committee decides the order in which traditions are approached and the scope of each module (a text, a school or a whole tradition), and publishes both.
- A module that meets the criteria is funded within the annual budget, or the board states publicly why not (§2).
- The committee reviews these criteria yearly (§6.1).